Alida Ngwengang Angafor

Massachusetts, USA · Alidaangafor@gmail.com · Personal Website: alidaangafor.com

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Areas of specialization: Philosophy of cosmology, philosophy of time, philosophy of mind, epistemology (self-locating belief), metaphysics of the self, philosophy of artificial intelligence

My research interests lie at the intersection of philosophy of mind, metaphysics, and philosophy of physics. I am particularly interested in the self and the subjectivity of experience, and in what the first-person point of view means for our attempts to give an objective account of reality. My master's thesis asks what accounts for the subjectivity of phenomenal consciousness. I argue that experience is always for someone, and that this is best explained by a subject that persists across its experiences, rather than by a momentary self constituted by experience. During my PhD, building on this work, I hope to examine how the first-person perspective figures in our understanding of the physical world, including questions about time, the arrow of time, and self-locating belief in cosmology. In other words, I hope to use what we learn about subjectivity to clarify what we can mean by an objective description of the world.

EDUCATION

M.A., Philosophy · Central European University, Vienna, Austria · 2024–2026

- Thesis: "Understanding the First-Person Viewpoint from the Third: Some Remarks on Being Someone." Supervisor: Lisa Doerksen.
- The thesis argues that the subjectivity of phenomenal consciousness, the fact that every experience is for someone, is grounded in a persisting subject rather than a self constituted only within momentary experience. It engages Nagel, Biro, Zahavi, Strawson, representationalist theories of consciousness, and no-self views.
- Graduate coursework: Laws of Nature (Ferenc Huoranszki); Objectivity (Maria Kronfeldner); Advanced Epistemology and Beliefs and Desires (Katalin Farkas); Epistemology (Phyllis Pearson); Ethics (Simon Rippon).

B.A., Philosophy and Sociology, Minor in Astronomy · Dartmouth College, Hanover, NH · 2017–2021

- Capstone project: *Knowledge Through Imagination*, supervised by Peter Lewis.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

"Where Do We Go Between Experiences? Existential Subjectivity and the Self in Experience" · Journal article in preparation, drawn from M.A. thesis

- Distinguishes existential subjectivity, the persisting subject that experience depends on, from experiential subjectivity, the self as it shows up within experience. Argues that a subject cannot be just its conscious experiences.

"Misalignment as Evidence of Human Error, Not Machine Agency" · Independent research project, 2026

- Argues that attributions of agency to AI systems rest on Dennett's intentional stance, which cannot distinguish genuine from as-if agency. Proposes that apparent AI agency is an unforeseen consequence of human optimization choices in training, so that misalignment reflects error and epistemic limits on the designers' side rather than machine agency.

"Whose Lie Is It? Agency Attribution in AI Deception Evaluations" · Independent research project, 2026

- Argues that describing model outputs as deceptive rather than erroneous presupposes a thick notion of agency (belief, goal ownership, a first-person standpoint) that current evaluations assume but do not test. Includes a two-experiment protocol testing perspective invariance and goal ownership in language model behavior.

Self-locating belief and the experience of time · PhD research project in development

- Asks what the mismatch between the block universe and our experience of time's passage implies about the reality of subjective experience, and whether there is a rational way to set self-locating credences.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant to Prof. Brad Skow · Department of Linguistics and Philosophy, MIT · Jan–Mar 2021

- Collected and summarized, with peers, articles on the scientific understanding of cause and effect from a philosophical perspective.
- Gave weekly presentations on the week's progress.

Research Assistant to Prof. Maron Greenleaf · Department of Anthropology, Dartmouth College · Jan–May 2021

- Researched the relation between development and inclusion, and the limits of how we conceptualize development.
- Wrote weekly summaries of the week's findings, along with a plan for the following week.
- Compiled a historical literature review on inclusion and exclusion in development.

Human Development Research Fellow · John Sloan Dickey Center for International Understanding, Dartmouth College · 2018–2021

- Completed six terms of paid research assistantships on faculty-led, field-based projects aimed at alleviating poverty in low-income countries, with the primary aim of developing technical skills and professional experience.

Research and Policy Intern · Latin America Youth Center, Washington, DC · 2014–2015

- Identified social problems in Washington, DC and wrote recommendations to address them, including research on the causes and prevention of teen drug use.
- Designed and administered surveys on adolescent drug use and analyzed the results to produce policy recommendations.
- Provided clerical support across a wide range of routine and special requests.

FELLOWSHIPS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

- Human Development Fellowship, John Sloan Dickey Center for International Understanding, Dartmouth College, 2018–2021
- Central European University Master's Scholarship (tuition and stipend), 2024–2026
- Dartmouth College Undergraduate Scholarship (partial tuition, room and board), 2017–2021
- Federal Pell Grant (partial tuition), 2017–2021

GRANTS

- PLATO Grant for Philosophy Programs, 2017. Funded a philosophy essay competition I organized for peers at Columbia Heights Educational Campus.

AWARDS AND DISTINCTIONS

- Abramson Foundation Scholarship Award, 2017–2021, for outstanding academic performance
- Future Business Leaders of America Scholarship Award, 2017–2021, for outstanding academic performance
- Black Youth Achievement Award, Springbrook High School, 2014, for outstanding academic performance

ADDITIONAL TRAINING

- CS 2881R: AI Safety, Harvard University (Prof. Boaz Barak), external participant, Fall 2026

TEACHING

Astronomy Teaching Assistant · Appalachian Mountain Club (Mt of Stars), Bretton Woods, NH · Jun–Aug 2019

- Hiked from hut to hut across the White Mountains, giving public lectures and answering questions on a range of astronomical subjects.
- Led night observing sessions with a variety of telescopes.
- Created and ran programs to introduce children to astronomy.

Teaching Assistant · Dartmouth Leadership Attitudes and Behaviors Program · Jan–Apr 2019

- Facilitated conversations about the identities and experiences that shape each person's values and practice of leadership.
- Through dialogue, created a space where participants could question how their values are lived out through actions, behaviors, and experiences.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Therapist Understudy · Nashoba Learning Group, Massachusetts · Sep 2026–present

- Deliver one-to-one instruction based on applied behavior analysis to students with autism spectrum and related disorders, under the mentorship of senior clinical staff.
- Collect and record behavioral and skills data (frequency, duration, and antecedent-behavior-consequence) across academic, daily living, and vocational programs to track student progress.

Child Welfare Caseworker · Chaffee County Department of Human Services, Salida, CO · Nov 2023–Aug 2024

- Managed a caseload of child welfare cases, where decisions about a child's safety often had to be made from evidence that was incomplete and still unfolding.
- Conducted intake assessments and investigated allegations of child abuse, neglect, and parent and child conflict, in order to determine whether a child needed to be placed outside the home.
- Conducted welfare assessments with families, listening closely to each person's account while weighing it against what could be observed and documented.
- Developed case plans with families and counseled them on parenting, family problems, parent and child relationships, and difficulties within their community.
- Testified in court on ongoing cases and shelter hearings.
- Built an Excel tracking system to hold competing case deadlines in view, so that no family's needs slipped through the cracks.

Crew Leader · SouthWest Conservation Corps · Mar–Nov 2023

- Led conservation field crews through long seasons of outdoor project work, coordinating each day's tasks while keeping the crew safe and working well together.
- Instructed and trained crews to complete technical conservation projects to a high standard, delegating project work and camp chores across ten-hour workdays.
- Coordinated logistics with project partners, a co-leader, and SouthWest Conservation Corps staff.
- Learned to make steady decisions in changing conditions, and to hold a group together when the work was hard and the days were long.

Field Guide · Pacific Quest Horticultural Therapy Program, Hilo, HI · Feb–Aug 2022

- Built and maintained rapport with students while holding the boundaries that furthered their therapeutic outcomes.
- Collaborated with other members of the treatment team, communicating desired outcomes so that each student's care stayed consistent.
- Made sure logistical tasks within the guide team were delegated and carried through.

Field Mentor · Elements Wilderness Therapy, Huntington, UT · Aug 2021–Feb 2022

- Spent 24 hours a day on eight-day shifts, building meaningful relationships and supporting students through the ups and downs of wilderness therapy.
- Held responsibility for students' safety, both physical and emotional.
- Worked closely with each student's therapist to carry out the week's treatment plan, while keeping the bigger picture in view for the students and the group.
- Practiced patience and close attention in a setting where trust had to be earned slowly, and where small moments often carried the most meaning.

Cabin and Trail Crew · Dartmouth College, Hanover, NH · Jun–Aug 2018

- Built and maintained trails on the summits of Mt. Moosilauke and Mt. Smarts.
- Repaired and maintained Dartmouth-owned cabins in the White Mountains.
- As site leader, guided peers in producing quality work.

State Secretary · Future Business Leaders of America, Washington, DC · Jan 2015–Jan 2017

- Oversaw daily administrative operations.
- Worked with fellow executive members to develop and implement new policies toward the organization's long-term goals.

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS AND ORGANIZATIONS

- Minorities and Philosophy (MAP), Central European University chapter, member, 2024–present
- Central European University Philosophy Club, member, 2024–present
- Dartmouth College Philosophy Club, member, 2018–2021
- Columbia Heights Educational Campus Philosophy Club, founder, 2015–2017

SKILLS

- **Languages:** English (native), Spanish (conversational), German (elementary)
- **Programming:** Python, C++, HTML, CSS

REFERENCES

Available upon request